tend to give me blackouts, and a lot of the time I would be with a woman and not remember a thing the next morning. Every now and again I would wake up with somebody in my bed and have no idea how she got there. It's obviously a pleasant surprise to find a gorgeous woman in your bed, but it's a little embarrassing having a total blank about it. I mean, what do you say? 'Hi, what's your name, how did you get here, and what did we do? And can we do it again?' It's only happened to me a few times in my life, but I'm not proud of those moments.

No … I've seen enough movies to know that that line of questioning gets you a slap in the face. Deservedly, too. Anyway, so this girl and I left Benky and the rest of the party and went to her place to get to know each other better. Unfortunately, though, by the time we got there, I was too out of it to close the deal. I tried, but I simply didn't have enough energy to get a signal. I passed out. Not good, because we did have a team curfew. Nothing formal, but just an understanding among the guys that during a Test match we wouldn't a) tonk it and b) get to bed in the early hours.

However …

I did have an uncanny ability to wake up at sunrise, irrespective of how pissed I'd been the night before … which is why, I guess, most people had no idea how much I was drinking. There was still time to sneak back to the hotel and, hopefully, get in before anyone noticed. But before I left, I enthusiastically finished what I had started the night before – it would've been rude not to. Now it's Sunday morning, it's 6.30 a.m., and her place is a good 20 kilometres from the hotel. I needed a taxi, and quick.

By now I was really panicking, because by the time the taxi arrived it was getting light and people would be starting to have their breakfast back at the hotel. I'm thinking, 'Oh shit.' I have to find a way of getting into the hotel and into my room without anyone realising I hadn't slept there.

I was still wearing my T-shirt, jeans and trainers from the night before, so, if any of the guys did see me, I couldn't just say that I'd just got up. If I could just get to my room, I'd be okay – my roommate on that tour, Paul 'Gogga' Adams, would definitely cover for me.

I managed to make my way through the lobby without anyone noticing me, and even into the lifts. But the lifts in this particular hotel opened straight onto the rooms. Peter Pollock – Shaun's dad, a fine, upstanding gentleman and legend of the game – was the convener of selectors at that stage. He is also a very religious man. As I walked out of the lift, I looked